IR II: Liberalism (AUW)

Political Science — Master Notes · by Jakob V. Stangel

Required reading: PG = **Goldstein & Pevehouse, *International Relations* — ch. 3, §3.1 (*The Waning of War*) & §3.2 (*Liberal Theories*) + ch. 7 (*International Organizations, Law, and Human Rights*).** · Lecturer: **Ayça Uygur Wessel.**

Theme of the lecture (AUW — deck). Liberalism as the **theoretical response to realism.** Realism explains rivalry, competition, security dilemmas and arms races — *but what about* European integration, IOs, international trade, arms-control agreements, and the democratic peace? **Liberalism's puzzle:** *if the international system is anarchic, why do states cooperate at all — and under what conditions is cooperation more or less likely?*

> ★ **The heart of the lecture:** liberalism keeps realism's starting point — **states are rational, self-interested actors under anarchy** — but reaches the opposite conclusion: **self-interest does not necessarily produce conflict.** Because some interests **overlap**, cooperation is often the rational choice: **self-interest → mutual benefits → reasoned cooperation → stable cooperation.** Two branches say how: **liberal institutionalism** — *institutions* make cooperation easier (information, reciprocity, monitoring, enforcement, the shadow of the future); and **liberal internationalism** — *domestic politics* shape what states want (the Kantian triangle: democracy + interdependence + IOs). *Liberalism ≠ being nice or naïve — it's "under what conditions is cooperation in states' own interest?"*

The red thread. For any case ask: *cooperation looks impossible under anarchy — so what makes it happen here?* Either the answer is **institutional** (rules/monitoring/reciprocity change the incentives) or it is **domestic** (regime type, interests, public opinion shape state preferences). Both keep the realist assumption of self-interested rational states.

Three things liberalism is NOT (deck). Liberalism *in IR* ≠ **economic liberalism** (free markets) ≠ **liberalism in domestic politics** (a left–right ideology). In IR it is a **theory of cooperation under anarchy.**

Key concepts / "modes" to use

- **The cooperation puzzle** — why cooperate under anarchy? (the question realism can't answer well).
- **Two branches: liberal institutionalism** (Keohane, Nye — international level) vs **liberal internationalism** (Kant — domestic/unit level).
- **Neoliberal institutionalism** — concedes realism's assumptions (unitary, rational, anarchy) but shows cooperation still pays.
- **Reciprocity** & the **shadow of the future · information/monitoring/transparency · enforcement · issue linkage**.
- **International regime** (Krasner) — "principles, norms, rules, and decision-making procedures around which actor expectations converge." *(An international institution ≠ an IO.)*
- **Complex interdependence** (Keohane & Nye) — multiple channels; disruption is costly for both sides (sensitivity vs vulnerability).

- **The Kantian triangle** — democracy + economic interdependence + international organizations.
- **Democratic peace** — democracies almost never fight *each other*.
- **Collective security · IGOs/NGOs · the UN · international law · just war · human rights (ch.7).**

Section-by-section main points

A. How liberalism sees the world *(deck + §3.1–3.2 intro)*

Core: liberalism is **more optimistic** than realism about peace and progress, but it is **not** starry-eyed: states are still **rational actors pursuing self-interest** — the liberal twist is that **self-interest often points to cooperation, not conflict.**

- **The chain (deck): self-interest → mutual benefits → reasoned cooperation → stable cooperation.** Cooperation is possible **without** becoming altruistic.
- **Realism vs liberalism on the "rules of IR":** realists see power politics as **timeless**; liberals see the rules as **slowly, incrementally evolving toward peace** — through the buildup of **international organizations + reciprocity** (and secondarily changing **norms/public opinion**). Liberalism draws on the **reciprocity and identity** principles, where realism draws on **dominance**.
- **§3.1 The Waning of War (the empirical backdrop):** contrary to the media impression, this is **one of the least warlike periods ever.** Battle-deaths have fallen sharply since WWII (tens of millions → millions → hundreds of thousands); the **last great-power war ended 60+ years ago**; today's conflicts (Syria, Yemen, Ukraine) are, by historical standards, **small wars.** → *This trend is what liberalism claims to explain and realism struggles to.*

B. The two branches of liberalism *(deck)*

Core: liberalism gives **two** answers to realism — one at the **international** level, one at the **domestic** level.

	Liberal Institutionalism	Liberal Internationalism
Key names	**Keohane & Nye**	**Kant**
Main question	How can states cooperate despite anarchy?	Why do states *want* different things?
Level of analysis	**International** (systemic)	**Domestic / unit** level
Core mechanisms	Information · reciprocity · monitoring · enforcement	Regime type · institutions · interests · public opinion
Simple claim	**Institutions make cooperation easier**	**Domestic politics shape state preferences**

*(Deck aside: liberal internationalism's focus on the domestic level mirrors what **neoclassical realism** does on the realist side — both "open up" the state rather than treating it as a black box.)*

C. ★ Liberal institutionalism — what makes cooperation possible *(§3.2.2 + deck)*

Core: **neoliberal (institutionalist)** thinking says to realists: "*Even granting your assumptions — unitary, rational states under anarchy — your pessimism doesn't follow.*" States cooperate often because it's in their interest, and **institutions** help them do it by **changing the incentives.** The engine is **reciprocity**, which enforces rules **without a world government.**

- **International institution ≠ IO (Krasner 1983).** An **international regime/institution** = "*principles, norms, rules, and decision-making procedures around which actor expectations converge*" — not just the UN or EU, but **monitoring arrangements, agreements, and platforms.** Institutions **structure repeated interaction.**
- **The four mechanisms (the deck's core — how institutions enable cooperation):**
  1. **The shadow of the future.** In a **one-shot** game, defecting is a free lunch — you grab the one-time **temptation payoff** and there is no tomorrow to pay for it. **Repeated** interaction changes the *arithmetic*: cheating once wins that bonus but **forfeits every future round of cooperation**, because the other side stops cooperating with you (tit-for-tat). So a purely selfish state weighs **one big cheat now** against **a stream of cooperative payoffs forever** — and when the future is **long enough and valued enough** (a low discount on tomorrow), the stream wins. *That* is why a **longer time horizon + more future interaction → higher cost of defection → cooperation more attractive**: cooperation becomes **self-enforcing not because states are nice, but because defection is bad maths.** *(The repeated **Prisoner's Dilemma** — see IR I — solved by **tit-for-tat**: cooperate first, then mirror.)*
  2. **Information changes the game.** Mutual cooperation is the jointly best outcome, yet each side fears the **sucker's payoff** (*I cooperate, you defect*) — and under **uncertainty** that fear makes both defect **pre-emptively**, even when both would rather cooperate. **Reporting** (what parties *say*) + **monitoring** (what they *actually do*) → **transparency** attacks the **fear, not the payoffs**: once I can verify you are complying, the risk of being suckered without recourse collapses, so I can safely **condition my cooperation on your observed behaviour.** Information also **makes reciprocity possible at all** — you cannot punish a cheat you cannot detect. *(Ex: the **European Semester** — the EU monitors member states' budgets to deter "excessive deficits.")*
  3. **Reciprocity & enforcement.** ***Reciprocity = responding in kind*** — meet **cooperation with cooperation** and **defection with punishment** (*positive* reciprocity rewards; *negative* reciprocity retaliates). It is **liberalism's answer to "who enforces the rules when there is no world government?"** — states police each other by making **defection cost you tomorrow's cooperation** (**tit-for-tat**: cooperate first, then mirror). So **cooperation ≠ harmony** — it needs bargaining and adjustment, and persists **only when defection has consequences. Why *tit-for-tat* in particular wins** (not "always cooperate," which gets exploited, nor "always defect," which kills cooperation): it is **nice** (never defects first, so two tit-for-tatters lock into mutual cooperation), **retaliatory** (punishes a defection *immediately*, so cheating never pays), **forgiving** (returns to cooperation the instant you do, so punishment does not spiral pointlessly), and **clear** (simple enough that the other side quickly *learns* the rule and sees that cooperating is in its own interest). Institutions supply the machinery to run it: **detect** (monitoring) → **respond** (reciprocity) → **raise the cost** (enforcement) → plus **issue linkage** (cooperate across issues so a concession on one trades for another). *(Ex: **rule-of-law sanctions** — the EU froze **Hungary's** funds.)* **The double edge:** the same reciprocity can spiral into **runaway hostility** — endless mutual punishment (**Israel–Palestine**).

4. **Interdependence makes conflict costly.** Complex interdependence (≠ friendship, ≠ one-way dependence): states are tied through **trade, investment, finance, supply chains, people, and communication** across *multiple channels*. The mechanism is **opportunity cost**, and it is worth seeing why this one works *differently* from the other three. Reciprocity and the shadow of the future deter by threatening a **future punishment someone has to choose to impose**; interdependence deters **automatically.** War or sanctions **sever the ties themselves**, so the **gains from trade you would lose** are a cost **built into the relationship in advance** — it bites the moment conflict starts, with no decision required. The denser the ties, the larger that standing cost → the **stronger the incentive to negotiate** rather than fight. Two refinements: **(a)** the cost is **mutual but usually asymmetric** — the **vulnerable** side (no good alternative: an economy dependent on one export market or one gas supplier) has far more to lose than the merely **sensitive** side (feels the disruption but can switch suppliers), so interdependence deters the **vulnerable** party more; **(b)** this is also realism's sharpest counter — interdependence was **high before 1914 and war came anyway**, so the mechanism **raises the price of conflict without making it impossible.** *(Sensitivity vs vulnerability is the textbook's distinction.)*

- **The neoliberal PD argument:** each actor can gain by defecting, but both lose if both defect; in **repeated** play, **strict reciprocity (tit-for-tat)** brings mutual cooperation. **Danger:** reciprocity can also produce **runaway hostility** — a nasty tit-for-tat of punishments (**Israel–Palestine**).
- **The EU — "a liberal-institutionalism masterpiece" (deck):** European states have **shared interests** *and* **incentives to defect**; the institutional solution — **permanent forums, common rules, monitoring, courts/enforcement, issue linkage, repeated interaction** — makes cooperation **easier and more predictable.** After centuries of war, Europe now enjoys a **stable peace.** *(Yet members still "cheat" over the years — cooperation is managed, not automatic.)*

D. International regimes & collective security *(§3.2.3–3.2.4)*

Core: two linked ideas, best kept apart. A **regime** is how liberalism operationalises cooperation in **one issue area**; collective security is that same logic applied to the **hardest** issue of all — stopping aggression (*all* against *any* aggressor).

1. International regimes *(§3.2.3)*

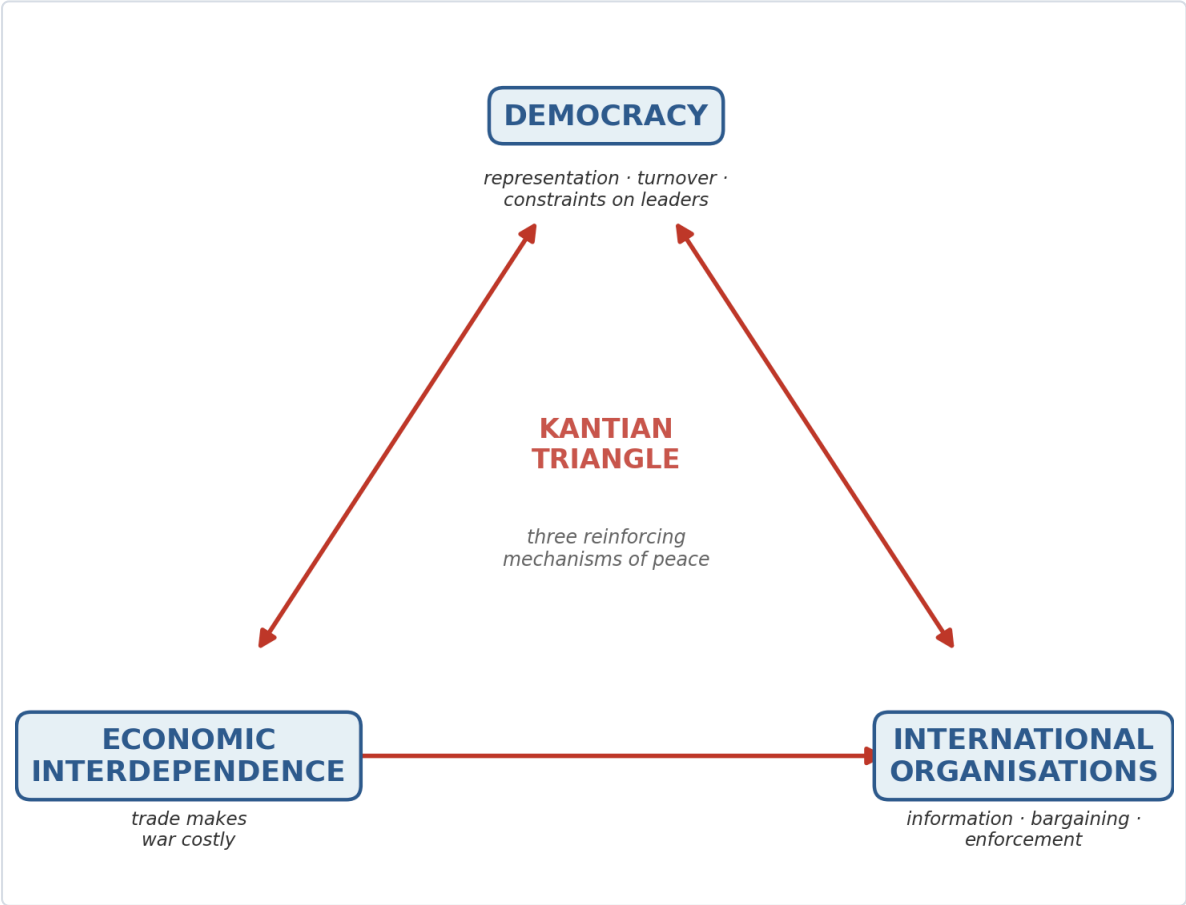
- **What it is:** the **rules, norms and procedures where state expectations converge** in a single issue area — arms control, trade, the law of the sea. *(Fuller Krasner definition in section C; a regime ≠ an IO — it's the shared rulebook, which may or may not sit inside a formal body.)*
- **What it does:** a regime **empowers rather than constrains.** It raises **transparency** (cheating is riskier) and "opens up new possibilities with more favourable cost–benefit ratios," so states join because it **helps** them pursue their interests, not because anyone forces them.
- **Hegemonic stability (a realist–liberal blend):** regimes work best when power is **concentrated** — a **hegemon** willing to enforce the rules and bear the costs. *But* once expectations have converged, a regime can **outlive the hegemon that built it** ("take on a life of their own": US economic regimes survived America's relative decline in the 1970s), and it often **embeds** in a permanent institution (**UN, NATO, IMF**).

2. Collective security *(§3.2.4)*

- **What it is:** the **security-side application** of regime logic (Kant's federation): a **broad alliance of most major powers** that pledges to oppose **aggression by *any* state** — "all against one," unlike an ordinary alliance aimed at a *named* external enemy.
- **Two conditions to work: (1)** members actually **keep their commitments** (no free-riding when the bill comes due); **(2)** they **agree on what counts as aggression.**
- **Its built-in limit:** it **cannot act against a great power** — the **veto** (or that power's own weight) blocks any united response.
- **Evidence:**
  - **League of Nations** — *failed*: the US never joined and members would not bear the costs, so **Japan and Italy** went unchecked in the 1930s. The **UN** is its successor.
  - **Gulf War 1990–91** — *worked*: Iraq's blatant conquest of Kuwait **united** the great powers behind a UN-authorised response.
  - **Iraq 2003** — *split* the great powers (France threatened a veto; the US, UK and Australia acted anyway) — collective security failing exactly where great powers **disagree**.

E. ★ Liberal internationalism & the Kantian triangle *(§3.2.1 + deck)*

Core: liberal internationalism opens the **domestic "black box"**: what a state *wants* (its **preferences**) depends on **who has a say inside it. Kant's three answers** to "how is peace possible?" form the **Kantian triangle.**



How to read it (the Kantian triangle). Kant gave **three** routes to peace, and they **reinforce** each other:

- **Democracy** — republics with **legislatures that check the leader** are constrained from going to war lightly (representation, leadership turnover, accountability). *(→ the democratic peace.)*
- **Economic interdependence** — **trade increases wealth and mutual dependence**, so war becomes **costly** and less attractive. *(Kant's "trade promotes peace"; realists are skeptical — interdependence was high before WWI, yet war came.)*
- **International organisations** — a **federation of states** (Kant's proposal → today's **UN**) provides **information, bargaining, and enforcement**, letting states forgo short-term gains for long-term cooperation. *(→ liberal institutionalism.)*
- **The point:** each corner makes the others more effective; together they explain why, despite anarchy, the world has grown **more peaceful.**
- **The causal chain of liberal internationalism (deck): domestic institutions + interests + incentives** (who benefits? who has influence?) → **state preferences** (what does the government *want?*) → **foreign policy** (which international choice follows) → **international outcome** (cooperation, conflict, or variation across states).
- **The *how* the arrow hides — why you must open the black box.** Realism reads "the national interest" straight off a state's **position in the system**; liberal internationalism denies there *is* a single interest waiting to be read. A state is **not one actor but an arena**: exporters want open trade while import-competing firms want tariffs; defence contractors and nationalists want a harder line while consumers and internationalists want cooperation; the median voter wants something else again. Each group has a **different preferred foreign policy.** What turns this clash into *the* state preference is **institutions** — the rules deciding **whose voice counts**: who can vote, who holds a veto, whom the leader must keep happy to stay in power, which lobby has access. So the chain really runs **competing domestic interests → (filtered by institutions) → the winning coalition's preference *becomes* "the national interest" → foreign policy.** The payoff — and the whole reason to open the box — is that the **same** external situation produces **different** policies in different states (and different policies in the *same* state once the domestic coalition shifts), because the **aggregating machinery differs.** A systemic-only theory like realism cannot generate that variation, which is precisely why **neoclassical realism** later had to borrow this move.
- **Who's in the black box:** president/PM/monarch, parliament, courts, bureaucracies, business & labour, elections, interest groups, media & public opinion. → *This is why liberalism sits at the **domestic level of analysis** (contra realism's systemic focus).*

F. The democratic peace *(§3.2.5 + deck)*

Core: the **democratic peace** = the strongly-supported empirical finding that **democracies almost never fight *each other*** — though they fight authoritarian states as much as anyone. *(Democratic peace ≠ "democracies are peaceful.")*

- **Not true:** that democracies are *generally* more peaceful — they fight as many wars as autocracies (the most war-prone states of the past two centuries were **France, Russia, Britain**).
- **True:** no major historical case of two democracies going to war with each other.
- **Why (candidate mechanisms — the deck's exercise):** ① **public opinion & representation** (the public, whose support wars need, resists); ② **peaceful leadership turnover** (no need to fight to change rulers); ③ **transparency & mutual understanding** (democracies read each other's

intentions); ④ **institutional constraints** (checks and balances slow the war decision). Also: democracies are usually **capitalist** with strong **trade interdependence**, and citizens **don't see other democracies as enemies.**

- **Why it matters theoretically:** the democratic peace is rooted in the **domestic** level → it **contradicts realism's** claim that the systemic level explains the most.
- **Caveats (don't oversell it): democratization/transition** may be *more* war-prone than stable regimes (e.g. Hamas elected 2006); and **democratic institutions can make cooperation harder** — legislatures raise **tariffs**, publics block IOs (US & the League of Nations; **Brexit**).

G. The institutions themselves — IOs, the UN, international law & human rights *(ch. 7)*

Core: ch. 7 is the **empirical** "**flesh**" on liberal institutionalism — the actual institutions through which states cooperate under anarchy. All of them are **limited by state sovereignty** (there is **no world government**), yet they **structure order** through norms, reciprocity, and legitimacy.

- **IGOs vs NGOs (§7.1): IGOs** = members are **states** (UN, OPEC, WTO, EU); **NGOs** = private/specialised (Amnesty, Greenpeace, Red Cross, religious bodies). The web of IOs has grown steadily → rising **interdependence.**
- **The UN (§7.2)** — "*the closest thing to a world government that has ever existed, but it is not a world government*." It exists because **states created it to serve their needs** (membership = **indirect leverage**). Key organs:
  - **Security Council** — maintains peace; decisions **binding**; **5 permanent members (US, UK, France, Russia, China)** with the **veto** + 10 rotating members. A single permanent-member **veto** kills a resolution → **paralysis when great powers are involved** (Russia shielding **Syria**).
  - **Peacekeeping** ("**Chapter 6½**"; **blue helmets**) — serve at the **host's invitation**, neutral between combatants (Nobel Peace Prize 1988).
  - **General Assembly** — all **193 members, one vote each** — a "global town hall" (declarations are **not** binding law).
  - **Secretariat / Secretary-General** — administration + **neutral mediator** ("good offices").
  - **Specialised agencies** — WHO, ITU, ICAO; and the economic ones (**World Bank, IMF, WTO**).
- **International law (§7.3)** — derives **not** from a world legislature but from **tradition and agreement. Four sources: treaties** (most important; *pacta sunt servanda* — treaties must be kept), **custom, general principles, legal scholarship. Enforcement** has no world police → rests on **reciprocity + collective response** (sanctions, reprisals) → therefore **depends on power** (easy to cheat on small issues / if you're strong). The **World Court (ICJ, The Hague)** hears only **state-vs-state** cases (limited jurisdiction).
- **Law & sovereignty (§7.4): diplomatic law** (immunity; sanctity of embassies — the **Iran hostage crisis 1979**) is the bedrock. **Just-war doctrine: laws *of* war (*jus ad bellum*)** — when war is legal (**only in response to aggression**; intent must be just) — vs **laws *in* war (*jus in bello*)** — how it may be fought.
- **Human rights (§7.5):** the idea of universal human rights **clashes with sovereignty** (**universalism vs relativism**; China/Russia call criticism "interference in internal affairs"). Sources: **religion, natural-law philosophy (Locke, Kant, Rousseau), the 18th-c. revolutions. Civil-political**

("negative") vs economic-social ("positive") rights. The **UDHR (1948)** sets norms (not binding law). **R2P (responsibility to protect, 2005)** — states must protect civilians from genocide/crimes against humanity (invoked for **Libya 2011**; *failed* in **Syria**). **War crimes → the ICC** (from **Nuremberg**'s "crimes against humanity" → Yugoslavia/Rwanda tribunals → the International Criminal Court).

Cases & examples

- **Nixon–China rapprochement (1969–72).** The US relaxed its trade embargo; three days later China released detained US citizens, then reciprocated further, culminating in Nixon's 1972 visit. → *Illustrates: **reciprocity** eliciting cooperation between rivals with no world government to enforce it.*
- **Israel–Palestinian tit-for-tat.** Reciprocity works both ways — sustained mutual punishment instead of cooperation. → *Illustrates: reciprocity's **runaway-hostility** danger (cooperation ≠ automatic).*
- **The European Union.** Shared interests + incentives to defect → an institutional solution (forums, rules, monitoring, courts, issue linkage, repeated interaction). → *Illustrates: **liberal institutionalism** at full strength — a stable peace built from institutions.*
- **Gulf War (1990–91).** Iraq's blatant annexation of Kuwait united all the great powers behind a UN-authorised response. → *Illustrates: **collective security working** — clear aggression + willingness to bear costs.*
- **Iraq War (2003).** The Security Council split (France's veto threat); the US/UK acted without UN authorisation. → *Illustrates: collective security's **limits** when the great powers disagree.*
- **R2P: Libya (2011) vs Syria (2011–).** A UN-authorised NATO campaign protected Libyan civilians; Syria's civilians got no such protection (Russian vetoes). → *Illustrates: the **norm shift** toward protecting civilians — and how **sovereignty + the veto** still block it.*

Key terms

Term	Meaning
Cooperation puzzle	Why do states cooperate under anarchy? (liberalism's central question)
Liberal institutionalism	Institutions make cooperation easier (Keohane & Nye; international level)
Liberal internationalism	Domestic politics shape state preferences (Kant; domestic level)
Neoliberalism	Concedes realist assumptions (unitary/rational/anarchy) but shows cooperation pays
Reciprocity / shadow of the future	Repeated interaction makes cheating costly → cooperation rational (tit-for-tat)
International regime	Rules/norms/procedures where actor expectations converge (Krasner)
Complex interdependence	Multiple cross-border channels; disruption costly for both (sensitivity vs vulnerability)
Kantian triangle	Democracy + economic interdependence + international organizations → peace
Democratic peace	Democracies almost never fight *each other*
Collective security	Broad alliance opposing aggression by any actor (League → UN)
UN Security Council / veto	5 permanent members can each block any resolution
International law (sources)	Treaties · custom · general principles · scholarship (enforced by reciprocity)
Just war	*jus ad bellum* (when war is legal — response to aggression) vs *jus in bello* (how fought)
R2P	Responsibility to protect civilians from genocide/crimes against humanity (2005)

Exam pointers

- State **liberalism's puzzle** and its answer: keep the **realist assumptions** (rational self-interested states under anarchy) but show **cooperation is often rational** — and that liberalism is **not** "being nice/naïve."
- Distinguish the **two branches** (institutionalism = international/institutions; internationalism = domestic/preferences) and name their theorists (Keohane & Nye; Kant).
- Explain the **four institutionalist mechanisms** (shadow of the future, information/monitoring, reciprocity/enforcement, interdependence) — and define an **international regime** (Krasner) with the institution ≠ IO distinction.
- Draw the **Kantian triangle** and explain the **democratic peace** precisely (democracies rarely fight *each other*; the mechanisms; the caveats).
- Use **ch.7 institutions** as evidence: the **UN/Security Council + veto**, **collective security** (Gulf War vs Iraq 2003), **international law** (4 sources, reciprocity enforcement), **just war**, **human rights/R2P**.

- **Contrast with realism:** same actors, opposite conclusion — see the table below.

★ Realism vs Liberalism — the payoff

	Realism (IR I)	Liberalism (IR II)
Core principle	**Dominance** (power)	**Reciprocity** (+ identity)
View of anarchy	Forces self-help & competition	Doesn't make conflict inevitable
Human nature / progress	Pessimistic, timeless	More optimistic; rules evolve toward peace
Key actors & level	Unitary states; **systemic** level	States **+ domestic** actors; institutions
Cooperation	Hard; fear of **relative gains** & cheating	Achievable via **institutions & absolute gains**
Central concepts	Power, security dilemma, balance of power, polarity	Institutions, regimes, interdependence, democratic peace
Both agree on	States are **rational actors** pursuing self-interest under anarchy	

The one-line contrast: realism asks "*who has the power?*"; liberalism asks "*under what conditions is cooperation in states' own interest?*"

★ Fun facts & memorable details (IR II: Liberalism)

> Sticky bits from Liberalism.

- **Liberalism ≠ nice.** It keeps realism's rational, self-interested states — it just asks "**when does cooperation pay?**" The optimism is about **incentives**, not about human goodness.
- **We live in one of the least warlike periods ever** — the last **great-power war ended 60+ years ago**, and battle-deaths have fallen from *tens of millions* to *hundreds of thousands* since WWII (the "waning of war").
- **Tit-for-tat** — cooperate first, then simply mirror the other side — is enough to sustain cooperation in a **repeated** Prisoner's Dilemma. No world government required.
- **Kant distrusted democracy** (he feared "mob rule" after watching the French Revolution) — yet his *republics* argument became the **democratic peace**, liberalism's favourite finding.
- **Democracies fight plenty of wars** — just not against *each other.* The three most war-prone states of the last 200 years were **France, Russia, and Britain.**
- **The UN can't heat its own building:** in the 1990s members owed so much in back dues that the UN couldn't afford to heat its NYC headquarters — the campaign slogan became "**Great nations pay their bills.**"
- **UN peacekeeping isn't in the UN Charter** — Dag Hammarskjöld joked the **blue helmets** were authorised under "**Chapter Six and a Half.**"

- **Diplomats' parking tickets:** immunity means NYC is owed ~**$16 million** in unpaid diplomatic parking fines — a tiny, vivid example of **sovereignty vs. law.**
- **Grotius returns:** the "**free seas**" principle became law when the **Dutch** (then the **British**) dominated trade and benefited from it — international law often codifies the **hegemon's** interest (cf. *Grotius, PET Module 2*).
